

Playing God

Manage a city or build the ultimate empire. Plus book reviews to help you keep up to date

TROPICO You rule

From the creators of the famous railway simulation *Railroad Tycoon II*, comes this game with a difference. Take a city management game, give it a deep tan in the Jamaican sun, add some rum and



calypso beats and you get *Tropicico*. The goal here is to rule a small tropical island. As the 'El Presidente', you take control of the working of your island and further its prosperity along with yours.

Tropicico doesn't take itself too seriously. At the start of the game you are given the

choice of which dictator you want to play—Fidel Castro, Evita Peron, Pinochet, and well, Lou Bega. Yes, Lou Bega of Mambo No 5 fame. The tongue-in-cheek humour makes the gameplay more absorbing. You might hear one of the citizens moan "Work, sleep, eat, sunbathe, there must be more to life".

You start off with a handful of islanders, and try and build your economy and provide better amenities to your citizens. Soon you change the occupation of the people from farming to those of exports, distilleries, cigar factories and so on. At the same time, you have to meet the demands of the people with entertainment, education and health care. If you don't, there's always another fascist dictator ready to take over. Playing Fidel Castro teaches you a lot of lessons, and it is up to you to use some of Machiavelli's tactics to win.

The graphics are nicely detailed and

well-animated, with the ability to zoom right in on individual buildings and people or pull back your view until you can see the entire island below you. The game uses the same graphics engine as *Railroad Tycoon II*, which adapts itself to this game quite well.

The control system uses a fairly simple interface, allowing you to place new buildings, set construction priorities, adjust wages, fees and rents, fire people, issue edicts and limit the number of workers in a particular building. If you can overlook the minor annoyances in the island's economy and trade system, this game is a winner. *Tropicico* is a politico-economic simulator and one of the best city building simulations in recent years. For any of you who have harboured secret ambitions of being a dictator, this game can give you vicarious pleasure.

Developer: PopTop Software

Genre: Strategy/Management

Contact: E-xpress Interactive, 022-887 0017

Web site: www.poptop.com/Tropicico.htm

Price: Rs 699

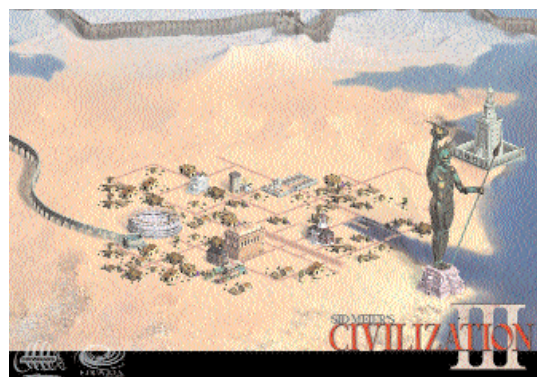
Rating: ★★★★★

CIVILIZATION III Electrifying!

To call *Civilization III* a game is like looking at the ocean and saying that the water is wet. There are strategy games, and then there's 'the *Civilization* experience'. Crafted by Sid Meier, the creative genius behind *Civilization* and *Alpha Centauri*, here's a sequel that continues the highly addictive journey through history.

Civilization III is a game of epic proportions where players can match their wits against the greatest leaders of the world in an all-out quest to build the ultimate empire. Elements such as Culture, Nation-

ality and the Arts can help players plan a new peaceful pathway to victory. The concepts of borders and a living map have advanced significantly since *Alpha Centauri*. Winning the game is not dependent on military power, but rather on culture. A 3,000-year-old city with an ancient coliseum, cathedral, library and university will have a higher culture rating, whereas a new backwater village with a small temple will barely register.



You can lure people from other countries around you simply on the basis of the strength of your culture. With enough →